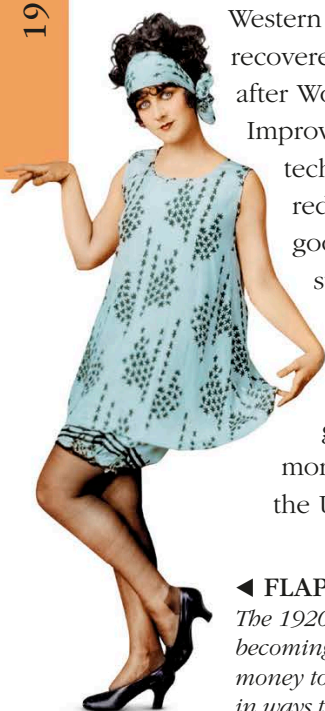


The Roaring Twenties

After the horrors of World War I, the 1920s was a decade of hope and excitement across the US and Europe. Economies flourished, and a new popular culture emerged. People spent money on fashion, music, going to the movies, and luxury items such as cars.



Western economies recovered quickly after World War I.

Improvements in technology helped reduce the price of goods. Wages rose steadily, so people had more money to spend. As businesses grew, they needed more office space. In the US, this led to the

construction of tall buildings known as skyscrapers, which started to change city skylines.

Movies became extremely popular, and by the mid-1920s, 50 million people went to the movies every week in the US. This was also a golden age for Black American dance, music, and theater.

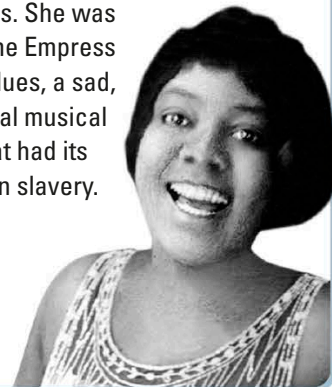
However, the good times ended abruptly in 1929, when the US stock market crashed, triggering an economic crisis that would eventually spread across the world.

◀ FLAPPERS

The 1920s was a period of newfound freedom for women in the West. After becoming part of the workforce during World War I, many had their own money to spend on fashion and entertainment. Young women who dressed in ways that expressed this new sense of fun and freedom were called "flappers."

BESSIE SMITH

The powerful voice of Bessie Smith (1894–1937) made her the highest-paid Black American musical artist of the 1920s. She was called the Empress of the Blues, a sad, emotional musical style that had its origins in slavery.



GROWTH OF RADIO ▼

In the 1920s, radios became much more affordable. People now had immediate access to news and entertainment. By the end of the decade, up to 40 percent of American households had a radio.



◀ THE JAZZ AGE

Jazz, a new musical style blending African rhythms and European harmonies, emerged in the Black American communities of New Orleans, and soon caught on across the whole country. Jazz artists such as Louis Armstrong and Joe "King" Oliver became celebrities. Jazz became so popular that the 1920s came to be known as the "Jazz Age."